

« BEFORE

Resistance to the new regime in South Vietnam was inextricably linked to the previous resistance to French imperialism.

POLITICAL CONTINUITY

The forerunners of the Viet Cong were the **Viet Minh**, a guerrilla network founded by **Ho Chi Minh** to **fight against the French**. After the partition of the country in 1954, cells of Viet Minh stayed in South Vietnam, in particular in the Mekong Delta and along the Cambodian and Laotian borders.



VIET MINH POSTER CA. 1954

It was the Diem regime that christened the forces of the National Liberation Front Viet Cong—short for “Vietnam Cong-san,” meaning Vietnamese communists. The Americans called them “VC,” “Victor Charlie”—a reference to the phonetic alphabet—and derivatives “Charlie,” and “Chuck.”

Early growth

The Viet Cong were divided into three operational forces—the primary one being made up of full-time regulars. This was divided into battalions, regiments, and, from 1965, divisions, which had an operational strength of 7,350 men. There were also full-time regional forces under provincial command and part-time guerrilla units, which were used primarily for village defense.

What the Viet Cong termed cadres were another key element in the insurgents’ political and military setup. More often than not, they were veterans of the war against the French with years of guerrilla experience behind them. At the start of the insurgency, the majority of cadres were so-called regroupées—South Vietnamese people who had moved to North Vietnam in 1954 and, following intensive military training and political indoctrination, moved back to the South.